Following ***Somananda*** and ***Utpaladeva***, *Abhinavagupta* believes that the mind-independence of matter is impossible. Trans-individual consciousness causes the manifestations that we experience to appear as if distinct from the subjects of experience. While ***Advaita-Vedanta*** understands the foundational consciousness in static terms, for this school it is self-conscious activity and will positing itself as apparently other than itself. It operates through projecting manifestations (*abhasa*) that are the contents of our experiences.

Against Buddhism he argues for the self-conscious subject (***atman***), the permanent background to experience, persisting as a stable unity that synthesises mental states. Without such a principle, there would only be momentary, self-contained, unrelated mental episodes. The key to understanding his philosophy is to be found in his critique of the notion that our ideas represent physical objects. He argues that consciousness can only represent what is itself conscious. We only know our experiences. It makes no sense to say that consciousness represents what is mind-independent because as soon as something is represented by consciousness it is no longer mind-independent.

Bondage to rebirth (***samsara***) is a state of ignorant self-limitation that understands the orthodox values of purity and impurity as objective. Liberation from rebirth consists in the recognition, typically through ***yoga*** and meditation, of oneself as a contracted form of the universal consciousness. Liberation is just this awareness: it is not a separate phenomenon produced by knowledge.

Further reading: Ingalls, Masson and Patwardhan 1990; Kahrs 1998; Padoux 1990; Pandey 1986; Sanderson 1992

Abhranta (unerring, reliable): Buddhists following ***Dharmakirti*** say that immediate perceptual sensation, which